

Ashfall fossil beds

Twelve million years ago a volcano erupted in North America, spreading a thick blanket of powdered glass (volcanic ash) and killing many prehistoric animals. The animals lay undisturbed until 1971. Welcome to the Ashfall Fossil Beds!



A RARE FIND

Hundreds of well-preserved mammal skeletons were found at Ashfall Fossil Beds in northeastern Nebraska, many complete, which is incredibly rare. Some of the animals survived the volcano's first eruption, but ash came to lie about 1–2 ft (50 cm) deep, and gradually filled their lungs as they attempted to graze. Ash is made up of tiny shards of glass—the animals didn't stand a chance.

Barrel-bodied rhinoceros
(*Teleoceras*)